

Overseas Territories

Some territories around the world belong to countries that lie far away from them geographically. Many of these overseas lands were once part of past colonial empires. Some now have their own local governments, but many have decided against independence in order

to keep strong trade connections, economic support, or military protection from the country they are linked to. A number of overseas territories are uninhabited islands. The UK administers the most overseas lands, followed by France, the US, and the Netherlands.

Australia

Ashmore and Cartier Islands

🏠 Population: 0

📏 Area: 2 sq miles (5 sq km)

Lying about 199 miles (320 km) northwest of Australia, this territory consists of four uninhabited coral reef islets. The first Europeans to discover them were British Captain Nash, aboard his ship *Cartier* in 1800, and Captain Samuel Ashmore, in 1811.

Christmas Island

🏠 Population: 2,200

📏 Area: 52 sq miles (135 sq km)

This island in the Indian Ocean was named, on Christmas Day, 1643, by a British sea captain. Flying Fish Cove is its main settlement and port, where most islanders live.



Thousands of red crabs migrate from Christmas Island to the ocean each year.

Cocos Islands

🏠 Population: 600

📏 Area: 5.5 sq miles (14 sq km)

Two of the 27 tiny Cocos Islands in the Indian Ocean are inhabited. They are centers for fishing, snorkeling, and bird-watching.

Coral Sea Islands

🏠 Population: 0

📏 Area: 1 sq mile (3 sq km)

On the edge of Australia's Great Barrier Reef, these tiny isles are visited by seabirds.

Heard and McDonald Islands

🏠 Population: 0

📏 Area: 159 sq miles (412 sq km)

This territory in the southern Indian Ocean is about 1,050 miles (1,700 km) from Antarctica. The volcanic islands are a haven for wildlife.

Norfolk Island

🏠 Population: 1,800

📏 Area: 14 sq miles (36 sq km)

Lying 994 miles (1,600 km) northeast of Sydney, Australia, Norfolk Island was formerly a prison colony for convicts exiled from the UK.

Denmark

Faroe Islands

🏠 Population: 51,600

📏 Area: 538 sq miles (1,393 sq km)

The Faroe Islands are 18 rugged, volcanic isles in the North Atlantic Ocean. Viking warriors once lived on them, around 1,200 years ago.

Greenland

🏠 Population: 57,600

📏 Area: 836,300 sq miles (2,166,000 sq km)

Greenland is the world's largest island that is not a country. Two-thirds of the territory lies in the Arctic Circle.

France

Clipperton Island

🏠 Population: 0

📏 Area: 2.5 sq miles (6 sq km)

This remote island in the east Pacific Ocean takes its name from the 18th-century English pirate John Clipper, who is said to have hidden here. At its center is a large, nutrient-rich lagoon with an abundance of plant life.

French Guiana

🏠 Population: 290,000

📏 Area: 35,135 sq miles (91,000 sq km)

On the northeast coast of South America is French Guiana, a region that is 90 percent dense jungle. Most people live in its largest city, Cayenne, or other towns on the coast.

French Polynesia

🏠 Population: 295,100

📏 Area: 1,609 sq miles (4,167 sq km)

With 118 islands spanning the five archipelagos of Austral, Gambier, Marquesas, Society, and Tuamotu in the South Pacific, French Polynesia is rich in beaches, lagoons, and waterfalls. The largest island is mountainous Tahiti.

French Southern and Antarctic Lands

🏠 Population: 0

📏 Area: 169,800 sq miles (439,781 sq km)

These remote, rugged islands lie in the southern Indian Ocean and off the Antarctic coast. Home to colonies of penguins and other seabirds, some of these isles are conservation areas with scientific research stations based on them.